# THE WORLD ACCORDING TO GEN ALPHA

**THE GENERATION BORN FROM 2010–2025 IS SPEAKING A NEW LANGUAGE OF FEELINGS AND BOUNDARIES. THE CHALLENGE LIES IN HOW ADULTS HEAR, INTERPRET AND RESPOND TO IT**

By SONALI ACHARJEE

IN **a reel making the rounds online as part of the viral 'Still Alive' trend** inspired by comedian Samay Raina's stand-up special of the same name, a seven-year-old boy turns to his father and says, simply, "I love you, Dad." The father is visibly taken aback. For a fleeting moment, he appears unsure whether to laugh, pull his son into an embrace, or return the words. What comes naturally to the child proves less instinctive for the parent. The video captures a dilemma many adults are increasingly confronting: how to respond to a generation that expresses its feelings with a candour they themselves were rarely taught.

That candour is not restricted just to affection. Children today are equally likely to state when they are upset or uncomfortable. "I need space" is a phrase parents today hear commonly. The children are not being rude, they are simply saying, "I need a few minutes to calm down before I can engage again."

Being honest and open about their feelings are traits that are especially noticeable among the cohort now known as Generation Alpha, generally defined as those born between 2010 and 2025 and currently ranging from toddlers to their early teens. They are being raised largely by Millennials, or Gen Y, born between 1981 and 1996, as well as older Gen Z parents, born in the late 1990s. Many authority figures shaping their lives belong to Gen X, born between 1965 and 1980.

## NEW EMOTIONAL VOCABULARY

What makes Gen Alpha different? Their early, immersive exposure to digital technology is encouraging a more expressive, immediate style of communication while also shaping emotional resilience, identity and social interactions, according to an Indian study, 'Navigating the Digital Paradox', published last year in the *International Journal for Multidisciplinary Research*. Children today also live in an information environment where nearly every claim can be verified, every rule questioned and every feeling named. This has given them both the vocabulary and the confidence to express their thoughts and emotions.

"Children aren't actually feeling emotions differently, they are simply being taught to label and express them much earlier and more openly," says Dharini Kothari, a psychological counsellor specialising in the mental health of teens and adults. Psychological and self-help terms now appear frequently in everyday conversations. "Today's children have greater exposure to words like 'triggered', 'boundaries' and 'positive manifestation' through schools, parents and social media," says Kareena Mehta, founder and psychotherapist at the Mumbai-based

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